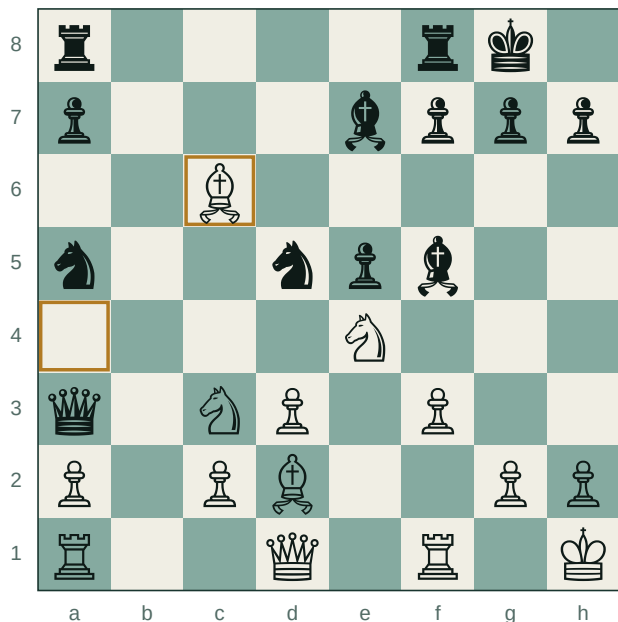


Intermediate moves: Black, move 16

Intermediate moves

Black to move



Previous move: 16.Bxc6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Nxc3 17. Nxc3 Nxc6

16...Nxc3 The knight captures the knight on c3. From c3 it attacks queen on d1 and knight on e4. Recorded reply: **17.Nxc3**.

17...Nxc6 The knight captures the bishop on c6.

At the end, nominal material is White 31 / Black 33 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on c6. Check for tactical protection.